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Smash Hits



GOLDEN TOUCH
Chirag (L) and Satwiksairaj competing in the Asian Games, Oct. 1

THE DOUBLES IN BADMINTON IS LIKE WATCHING A SPORTING PAS DE DEUX, but not one with too much time for slow-moving elegance: this is the part of ballet that involves leaps, pirouettes, rapid exchanges at the net, fast smashes, unbelievable retrievals and spatial awareness between the partners. As a men's doubles pair, Chirag Shetty and Satwiksairaj Rankireddy have all that, but what they also bring to the court is a distinct swagger. To describe themselves, though, they dipped into tennis. "I like Federer; he likes Nadal. Sometimes when we both come together, it's Djokovic," said Satwiksairaj, while speaking to INDIA TODAY before the Asian Games in September 2023. That expressed more than just honest admiration of their favourite stars. It spoke to how they work so telepathically as to almost become one organismic unit.

Like Djoker, SatChi—as they are fondly called by fans—had a stellar year on court. They won the Asiad gold, India's first in the sport, at Hangzhou, China; were champions at the Asia Championships in Dubai in April; claimed three other titles; and climbed up to World No. 1 in October, becoming the first Indian pair to reach that pinnacle in men's doubles. It came as no surprise when the two were named for the Khel Ratna—India's top sporting honour—for 2023. One thing to have a winning year; quite another to do so while patenting an attractive, aggressive style. Their swagger is most evident in post-match celebrations, in which Satwiksairaj lets his feet go and Chirag his jersey. (Do watch their jig to the *Dangal* title track at the Hangzhou Asian Games.) It's a ritual that started when India won the Thomas Cup in 2022; now it's a part of the SatChi code, much like the chest bump was for another famous racket pair—tennis legends Leander Paes and Mahesh Bhupathi.

In a sport that once was the turf of the Chinese and Indonesians, the Indian duo brings a fearlessness that's roughly equivalent to what Virat Kohli brought to cricket. The intent, says Chirag, is not to intimidate opponents, but to boost their own morale. Their never-say-die attitude, which has seen them bounce back from a game down or put up a mighty fight even when losing, is a kinetic force that ensures the off days are few and far between. Also, they learn from mistakes. After losing eight straight matches to the Malaysian pair of Aaron Chia and Soh Wooi Yik, SatChi didn't let the record